Headache: the question flow

A first draft for Dr Ogwuna and Dr Daleng to correct

This is a proposal, not clinical guidance. Every question, every red flag and every outcome here is yours to change, delete or reorder.

The aim: help a person with a headache decide how fast to seek care. It never names a cause or a diagnosis.

Please mark anything unsafe, missing, badly worded, or wrongly ranked. Disagreement is the most useful feedback.

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How the flow works

Short yes/no questions, red flags first, one of three outcomes

1. Red-flag questions come first. One "yes" stops the flow and gives the urgent outcome at once.
2. If all red flags are "no", it asks a few context questions (age group, pregnancy, how long).
3. It then gives one of three outcomes, always with warning signs to watch for.
4. Every screen carries: "This is a screening aid, not a diagnosis. If you are worried, seek care."
5. Built for SMS or USSD too: each question is a single short message answered 1 for yes, 2 for no.

EMERGENCY

Go to the nearest emergency unit now

CLINIC TODAY

See a clinician within 24 hours

SELF-CARE

Home care with clear warning signs

Your call:

Are three outcomes enough, or do you want a fourth, such as "see a clinician this week"?

Should timings (now, 24 hours) be different?

Step 1: red-flag questions

Any "yes" leads straight to EMERGENCY. Please check this list hard.

1. Did it come on suddenly and reach full pain within a minute (like a thunderclap)?
2. Is it the worst headache you have ever had?
3. Do you have a stiff neck, or a fever with the headache?
4. Any weakness, numbness, face drooping, trouble speaking or confusion?
5. Any new loss of vision, double vision, or a seizure?
6. Did it follow a head injury or a fall?
7. Have you fainted, or are you very drowsy and hard to wake?
8. Are you pregnant (or just given birth) with a severe headache, swelling or visual changes?

Questions for you

Is anything on this list wrong or missing?

Should "known HIV or on chemotherapy" or "age over 50 with a new headache" be red flags?

Is the pregnancy question worded safely?

Are 8 red flags too many for an SMS flow?

Step 2: if every red flag is "no"

A few context questions decide between CLINIC TODAY and SELF-CARE

A. How long have you had this headache?
Under 24 hours | 1 to 3 days | more than 3 days

B. Is it getting worse day by day, or waking you from sleep?

C. Do you have vomiting that will not stop, or cannot keep fluids down?

D. Are you over 50 with a headache that is new for you?

E. Do you have a long-term illness or a weak immune system?

F. Is the pain stopping you doing normal daily things?

CLINIC TODAY if any of:

B yes | C yes | D yes | E yes | A is more than 3 days | F yes with fever

SELF-CARE if:

none of the above apply

Your call: are these thresholds sensible, and is anything missing for children?

Step 3: what the person sees

Wording is as important as logic. Please rewrite it freely.

EMERGENCY

"Your answers suggest you should get urgent medical care now. Go to the nearest emergency unit or call emergency services. Do not wait. Do not drive yourself if you feel unwell."

CLINIC TODAY

"Please see a doctor or nurse within 24 hours. If you get a stiff neck, confusion, weakness, vision change or a sudden severe worsening, go to emergency care at once."

SELF-CARE

"This does not look like an emergency. Rest, drink fluids and take your usual pain relief as directed on the pack. See a clinician if it lasts more than 3 days or gets worse, or if any warning sign appears."

Your call: should the SELF-CARE text mention any specific medicine, or never? We lean towards never, so the app does not advise on drugs.

What we are asking, and what we will not do

Your corrections shape the next version

Please tell us:

1. Which red flag or question is unsafe, missing or wrongly worded?
2. Are the three outcomes and their timings right?
3. Which patients should the app refuse to triage at all, such as young children?
4. The single most important change to make first.

What we will not do

Name or suggest a diagnosis.

Advise on medicines or doses.

Publish anything until you have reviewed it.

Use your name publicly without your written agreement.

Reply by voice note, message or a marked-up copy. A few honest lines is plenty. Thank you.